LAMENTATIONS

Conversational Version

Jerusalem Deserted

1:**1**How lonely the city sits that used to bustle with people!
She's like a widow that was once great among the nations!
The princess among the provinces has become a slave!
2She cries bitterly at night; tears are on her cheeks.
Nobody among her lovers is there to comfort her.
Her friends have betrayed her
and become her enemies.
3Judah has gone into exile in suffering and hard servitude;
she's spread out among the nations now;
with no resting place.
Her pursuers have caught up with her in the middle of her distress.
4The roads to Zion are in mourning
because nobody attends the appointed festivals.
Her gates are desolate, her priests groan,
her virgins suffer, and she suffers bitterly herself. **Lam 1:1-4**
5Her adversaries have become her masters; her enemies prosper.
The LORD has made her suffer for her many sins.
Her children have gone away captive to the foe.
6The majesty is gone from Zion;
her officials are like bucks that can't find pasture;
they've fled away weak before their pursuers.
7In her time of suffering and homelessness,
Jerusalem remembers her treasured things from before;
when her people fell to her adversaries and nobody helped her,
the enemies gloated over her and mocked her downfall.
8Jerusalem sinned grievously, so she's become filthy.
Everybody that honored her before despises her now,
because they've seen her nakedness;
she groans and turns away. **Lam 1:5-8**
9Her uncleanness was in her skirts;
she didn't give any thought to her doom;
so she's fallen terribly with no comforter.
10The foe has reached out for her treasured things;
she has watched the nations invade her sanctuary,

people you commanded not to enter your community.
11 The people are groaning as they look for bread;
they've given their treasured things for food to stay alive;
"Look, LORD, I'm despised.
12 *Is it nothing to you that go by?*
Look and see if there's any pain like my pain
that was severely dealt out to me,
that the LORD inflicted in his fierce anger. **Lam 1:9-12**
13 *He sent fire from on high into my bones, and it descended on them.*
He spread a net for my feet and turned me back;
he left me desolate and faint all day long.
14 *He has tied my sins together into a yoke around my neck;*
he has made my strength fail,
and turned me over to those I can't withstand.
15 *The Lord has rejected the strong men that are with me;*
he has called an appointed time against me to crush my young men;
like a winepress he has trodden down the young virgin Judah.
16 *I weep for those things; my eyes run down with tears*
because there's no comforter near to restore my soul.
My children are desolate because the enemy has prevailed." **Lam 1:13-16**
17 Zion holds out her hands, but there's no one to comfort her;
the LORD has commanded against Jacob
that his neighbors would be his enemies;
Jerusalem has become something filthy in their minds.
18 *"The LORD is good; I've rebelled against his command;*
listen now, all you nations, and look at my pain;
my virgins and young men have gone into captivity.
19 *I called to my lovers, but they deceived me;*
my priests and elders perished in the city
as they looked for food to stay alive.
20 *Look, LORD, because I'm in distress; my soul is in turmoil.*
My heart's upset because I've been rebellious.
The sword bereaves in the street; it's like death in the house. **Lam 1:17-20**
21 *They've heard that I'm groaning with nobody to comfort me.*
My enemies have heard about my trouble;
they're glad you've done it.
Bring the time you've promised,
and let them be like me.

[22]*Pay attention to their sinfulness,,*
and deal with them like you've dealt with me for my sins.
I groan a lot, and my heart is faint." **Lam 1:21-22**

Destruction for Sin

2[1]How the Lord in his anger has covered Zion under a cloud!
He has thrown down Israel's splendor from heaven to earth;
he hasn't remembered his footstool in his wrath.
[2]Without mercy the Lord has swallowed up the residents in Jacob.
In his anger he has thrown down Judah's fortresses
and leveled the kingdom and its officials to the ground in dishonor.
[3]In his fury he has cut down Israel's power
and stopped restraining the enemy.
He has burned like a fire in Jacob
and consumed it everywhere.
[4]He has bent his bow like an enemy;
he has set his right hand like an adversary
and killed everybody we took pride in.
He has poured out his anger like fire in the tent of Zion. **Lam 2:1-4**
[5]The Lord has become like an enemy;
he has swallowed up Israel,
laid its palaces in ruins,
destroyed its fortresses,
and multiplied mourning and groaning in Judah.
[6]He's violently treated his Tabernacle like a garden shed
and laid in ruins his appointed meeting place.
The LORD has stricken from memory
the appointed festivals and Sabbaths in Zion,
and deposed king and priest in his angry indignation.
[7]The Lord has rejected his altar, disowned his sanctuary,
and delivered to the enemy the walls of its palaces.
A clamor was raised in the LORD's Temple
like that of an appointed festival day.
[8]The LORD decided to destroy the wall around Zion.
He stretched out a line
and didn't restrain his destroying.
He made rampart and wall mourn;
they've broken down together. **Lam 2:5-8**
[9]Its gates have sunk into the ground;

he has ruined and broken its bars
and *scattered* its king and officials among the nations.
There's no law anymore;
prophets don't have visions from the LORD.
10The elders of Zion sit silent on the ground;
they've thrown dust on their heads
and wrapped themselves in burlap.
The virgins of Jerusalem have bowed their heads to the ground.
11My eyes are worn out from crying;
my spirit is in turmoil;
my heart is poured out on the ground
because my people have been destroyed;
the little ones and babies pass out in the street.
12They ask their mothers, *"Where is the bread and wine?"*
as they faint like wounded men in the city streets,
as their life dies out on their mother's chest. **Lam 2:9-12**
13What can I say for you?
What can I compare you to, young woman in Jerusalem?
What can I liken you to, as I comfort you, young virgin in Zion?
Your ruin is as wide as the sea; who can restore you?
14Your prophets have deceived you with false visions;
they haven't exposed your iniquity to restore you from sin;
they've seen false, misleading oracles for you.
15Everybody that goes by claps their hands at you;
they gasp and shake their heads at Jerusalem,
"Is this the city they used to say was 'perfectly beautiful,
a delight to the whole world'?"
16Your enemies mock you;
they scoff and snarl,
and shout, *"We've swallowed you up!*
That's what we've been waiting for;
at last it's here to see." **Lam 2:13-16**
17The LORD has accomplished his purpose
and carried out the threat he ordained long ago.
He has destroyed without pity
and enabled your enemies to celebrate over you
and increased the power of your adversaries.
18Their heart appealed to the Lord,
"Resident of Zion, let your tears run down like a river day and night;

don't give yourself any relief or let your eyes rest.
19 *Get up, cry out loud at the beginning of the night watches;*
pour your heart out like water to the Lord;
lift your hands up to him for the life of your little ones
who are faint from hunger at the end of every street."
20 See, LORD, look! Who else have you ever dealt with this way?
Should women eat their offspring, little babies born healthy?
Should prophet and priest be killed in your sanctuary? **Lam 2:17-20**
21 Young and old lie on the ground in the streets;
my virgins and young men have fallen by the sword.
You've slain them in your anger,
slaughtered them without mercy.
22 You invited terrors on every side of me as to an appointed festival.
Nobody escaped or survived your anger.
My enemy destroyed the ones I cared for and raised. **Lam 2:21-22**

Hope in the LORD's Faithfulness

3:1 I have seen suffering
under the rod *God* used in his anger.
2 He has driven me out and made me walk in the dark;
3 he has turned his hand against me repeatedly all day.
4 He made my skin and body waste away,
and broke my bones. **Lam 3:1-4**
5 He besieged me with bitterness and hardship.
6 He made me live in dark places
like the dead from long ago.
7 He walled me in so I couldn't escape
and put heavy chains on me.
8 Even when I call for help,
he shuts out my prayer. **Lam 3:5-8**
9 He has blocked my road with hewn stones
and made my paths crooked.
10 He's like a bear lying in wait for me,
like a lion in unexpected places.
11 He dragged me off the road, tore me to pieces;
and made me desolate.
12 He bent his bow and made me a target for his arrow; **Lam 3:9-12**
13 he shot deep into me the arrows from his quiver.

14I'm a laughingstock to my people,
mocked in musical ditties all day.
15He filled me with bitterness
and made me drink wormwood.
16He cracked my teeth with gravel
and made me grovel in the dust. **Lam 3:13-16**
17I've been set apart from peace
and forget what happiness is like.
18So I say, *"My strength is gone,*
and so is my hope in the LORD."

19Remember my suffering and homelessness.
20I certainly remember
and am humbled within. **Lam 3:17-20**
21I recall this and have hope *from it*:
22The LORD's love never stops *coming*;
his mercies don't end.
23His faithfulness is great;
it's renewed every morning.
24I say to myself, *"The LORD is my portion;*
so I have hope in him." **Lam 3:21-24**
25The LORD is good to those who depend on him,
people that look for him.
26They do well to wait silently for his salvation.
27It's good for people to bear the yoke when they're young,
28to sit alone in silence, since *God* has laid it on them,
29to put their mouth in the dust—maybe there's hope,
30to turn their cheek to their abuser,
to be filled with disgrace;
31because the LORD won't reject forever. **Lam 3:25-31**
32If he causes grief, he'll have mercy
according to his enduring love;
33because he doesn't willingly hurt people or grieve them.
34-36 God doesn't approve
of crushing every prisoner in the land under his feet,
of depriving people of justice in the presence of the Most High,
of defrauding people in his lawsuit.

[37]Who is there that speaks and it happens
unless the Lord has commanded it?
[38]Don't both good and bad come from the Most High? **Lam 3:32-38**

[39]Why should we complain in light of our sins?
[40]Let's examine our ways and return to the LORD.
[41]Let's lift up our heart and hands toward God in heaven;
[42]we've sinned and rebelled; you haven't pardoned us.
[43]You've covered yourself with anger and chased us;
you've slain without pity.
[44]You've wrapped yourself in a cloud
so no prayer can get to you. **Lam 3:39-44**
[45]You've made us residue and refuse among the nations.
[46]Our enemies rail out against us.
[47]Panic and pitfall descend on us, devastation and destruction.
[48]My eyes run with streams of tears
because my people are being destroyed.
[49]My eyes will keep pouring out
[50]till the LORD looks down from heaven and sees.
[51]My eyes bring pain to my soul
because of all the residents in my city.
[52]For no reason my enemies hunted me down like a bird;
[53]they've silenced me in the pit, and put a stone over me;
[54]water closed over my head; I said, *"I'm lost."*
[55]I called to you, LORD, from down in the pit. **Lam 3:45-55**
[56]You heard my plea
and didn't hide from my prayer for relief, my call for help.
[57]You came and said, *"Don't be afraid!"*
[58]Lord, you pled my case and redeemed my life.
[59] LORD, you've seen my oppression; judge my case.
[60]You've seen their revenge, their schemes against me.
[61]You've heard their taunts.
[62]My assailants' whispers aim at me all day.
[63]Look at their sitting and rising;
I'm what they mock in their song.
[64]Pay them back, LORD, according to what they've done;

[65]harden their heart so your curse will fall on them.
[66]Chase them in anger and destroy them from under the sky! **Lam 3:56-66**

The LORD's Anger Satisfied

4:[1]How the gold has tarnished; how pure gold has changed!
The holy stones lie scattered at the beginning of every street.
[2]The precious sons of Zion, worth their weight in gold,
are treated like clay pots that potters make!
[3]Even jackals nurse their young,
but my people have become cruel like wild ostriches.
[4]The infant's tongue sticks to the roof of its mouth for thirst;
little ones beg for bread, but nobody gives them any.
[5]People that used to eat delicacies sit desolate in the streets;
the ones brought up in purple lie on ash heaps.
[6]The iniquity of my people is worse than the sin of Sodom,
which was overthrown without hands in one moment.
[7]*Zion's* Nazirites were purer than snow, whiter than milk,
healthier looking than corals, like polished lapis lazuli. **Lam 4:1-7**

[8]Now they're darker than soot, not recognizable in the streets;
their skin is shriveled on their bones, withered like wood.
[9]Those killed with the sword are happier than those slain by hunger;
they pine away, stricken for lack of crops in the field.

[10]Merciful women boiled their own children;
they became their food because my people were being destroyed.

[11]The LORD has accomplished his wrath,
poured out his hot anger,
and sparked a fire in Zion that has consumed its foundations.
[12]The kings and inhabitants of the region
didn't believe enemies could get in the gates of Jerusalem. **Lam 4:8-12**

[13]Because of its prophets' sins and its priests' iniquities—
who shed the blood of good people in it—
[14]they wandered in the streets, blind and defiled with blood
so nobody would *even* touch their clothes.
[15]They shouted at them, *"Get away! Unclean! Don't touch!"*

So they fled and wandered.
People in the nations said, *"They can't stay here anymore."*

16The LORD has scattered them;
he won't continue to care *especially* about them;
they didn't honor the priests or bless the elders. **Lam 4:13-16**

17Our eyes failed *us*; looking for help was useless;
we certainly watched for a nation that couldn't save.

18People dogged our steps so we couldn't walk in the streets;
our end came near, our days failed, we were through. **Lam 4:17-18**
19Our pursuers were faster than eagles in the sky;
they chased us on the mountains and ambushed us in the desert.
20Our very breath, the LORD's anointed, was captured in their pits;
we'd said about *him*, *"In his shadow we'll live among the nations."*
21Celebrate and be happy, Edom that lives in Uz;
the cup will come around to you as well; you'll be drunk and naked.
22*The punishment for* your sinfulness is finished, Zion;
he won't exile you any longer.
But he'll punish your iniquity, Edom;
he'll expose your sins! **Lam 4:19-22**

Prayer for Restoration

5:1LORD, remember what's happened to us;
look at our disgrace!
2Our inheritance has been turned over to foreigners,
and our houses *belong* to aliens.
3We've become orphans without fathers;
our mothers are like widows.
4We have to pay for drinking water and buy wood.
5Our drivers *put yokes* on our necks;
we're worn out; we can't get any rest. **Lam 5:1-5**
6We've submitted to Egypt and Assyria to get enough bread.
7Our fathers sinned, and they're gone,
but we have to suffer for their sins.
8Slaves rule us; nobody can deliver us from them.
9We risk our lives *just* getting bread

because of the sword in the open country.
[10]Our skin is hot like an oven,
because of the burning heat of famine.
[11]They rape the women in Zion
and the virgins in the towns in Judah. **Lam 5:6-11**
[12]They hang up officials by their hands
and show no respect for old men.
[13]Young men work at the grinding mill
and stagger under loads of wood.
[14]Elders are gone from the city gate,
young men *have quit* their music.
[15]The joy in our hearts is gone;
our dancing has turned into mourning.
[16]The crown has fallen from our head;
misfortune awaits us because we've sinned!
[17]Our heart is faint because of it;
our eyes are weak.
[18]Jackals prowl in desolate Zion. **Lam 5:12-18**

[19]LORD, you rule forever;
your throne goes on for endless generations.
[20]Why don't you keep us in mind forever?
Why abandon us so long?
[21]Restore us to yourself, LORD, so we can be restored;
renew our days as of old,
[22]unless you've completely rejected us
and are really angry with us. **Lam 5:19-22**

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